FAMILY SUPPORT

Supporting a loved one during recovery

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Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

How can you support a loved one?

Helping someone recover from a heart event may involve meals, transport, appointments, and emotional support. Start by asking what help they want. Respect their privacy and keep them involved in decisions. Agree on what you will discuss before calling on their behalf, and share the instructions accurately afterward. [1]

Learn the agreed care plan

With the patient’s permission, ask the team to explain instructions that involve you. Know which symptoms need a routine call and which require emergency help. Keep current medicine information and contact details accessible. If you do not understand a task, ask for a demonstration or written explanation. Do not make medicine changes or encourage extra exercise outside the prescribed plan. [1]

Agree on who does what

A shared schedule can reduce confusion. Decide who helps with transport, shopping, appointment reminders, and other tasks. Identify a family contact for updates when appropriate. If two people assist with medicines, make sure there is a clear recording system. Avoid assuming that someone else has already made a call or collected a prescription. A simple handover can prevent a concern from being overlooked. [4]

Listen without rushing to fix

Fear and frustration can be part of recovery. Give your loved one time to explain what is difficult. Ask whether they want advice, company, or help contacting a professional. Avoid telling them that they should feel grateful or recover faster. If emotional distress continues or disrupts daily life, encourage them to discuss it with their care team. Serious concerns about immediate safety need urgent attention.

Support independence safely

Ask which activities the patient can do alone and which need help for now. Rehabilitation should be guided by the team, rather than by pressure from relatives. Do not lift or move someone in a way you have not been taught. Tell staff about stairs, bathroom access, or other home difficulties. Practical details can help them explain safer ways to manage everyday routines.

Notice your own needs

Caregiving can take time and energy. Ask relatives or trusted friends for specific help, such as a trip to the pharmacy or preparing a meal. Keep your own medical appointments when possible. Tell someone if you are exhausted or struggling emotionally. Seeking support protects your well-being and can make the caregiving arrangement more sustainable. You do not have to carry every responsibility alone. [2,3]

Prepare for the next review

Review the support plan as your loved one recovers. Ask which tasks still need help and which they can manage alone. Share responsibilities in a way that respects the patient’s wishes and your own health.

References

1. American Heart Association. (n.d.). Communication tips for caregivers. https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/caregiver-support/communication-tips-for-caregivers

2. American Heart Association. (n.d.). Finding balance as a caregiver. https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/caregiver-support/busy-caregivers

3. MedlinePlus. (n.d.). Caregiver health. https://medlineplus.gov/caregiverhealth.html

4. National Institute on Aging. (n.d.). Sharing caregiving responsibilities. https://www.nia.nih.gov/health/caregiving/sharing-caregiving-responsibilities

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Ask about the program and appointment arrangements.
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